

FOR FIRST-TIME & SELF-PUBLISHING AUTHORS

The Author's Scam-Proof & Real-Cost Checklist

Know the warning signs before you sign anything — and know exactly what publishing your book should really cost.

01

15-POINT RED FLAG CHECKLIST
FOR SPOTTING PREDATORY
PUBLISHING COMPANIES

02

REAL-WORLD COST BENCHMARKS
FOR EDITING, DESIGN, FORMATTING &
MARKETING

You Wrote the Book. Don't Let the Wrong Deal Undo It.

"I lost three months and my savings to a company that promised a bestseller and delivered nothing." — a story we hear more often than we'd like.

The self-publishing industry has no gatekeeper. Anyone can build a website, call themselves a "publisher," and take payment from an author who just wants to see their name on a cover. Most are legitimate. Some are not. This guide gives you two tools to protect yourself and your budget — whether you work with Collingwood Press, another publisher, or go fully independent.

\$2K–\$25K+

A realistic range for professional self-publishing, depending on the services and scope required. A quote far outside this range deserves closer examination.

15

Warning signs covered in this checklist, grouped into contracts & money, communication, and promises & claims.

6

Core services benchmarked with real cost ranges: editing, cover design, formatting, ISBN, distribution, and marketing.

How to Use This Guide

1

Before signing with any publishing company or freelancer, run their pitch, quote, and contract through the Part One checklist.

Any single checked box is worth pausing on. Three or more is a serious concern.

2

Use the Part Two benchmarks to see whether the quote you received is broadly consistent with professional market pricing.

A very low quote may indicate reduced scope; a very high one should come with a clear explanation of the added value.

3

Use the self-assessment near the end to decide whether you have enough information to move forward, need answers in writing, or should seek a second opinion before signing.

■ PART ONE

15 Red Flags of a Predatory Publisher

Check every item that applies to a company, contract, or offer you are evaluating. One red flag does not automatically prove bad intent—but several appearing together may indicate a pattern worth investigating before you pay.

MONEY & CONTRACTS

- ☐ **Full payment demanded upfront, with no milestone-based structure.**
Ask whether payments can be tied to clearly defined stages or deliverables—for example, editing completed, cover approved, final files delivered.
- ☐ **The contract is vague about what you'll actually receive.**
Terms such as “full editing” or “complete marketing package” should come with a defined scope, timeline deliverables, and revision policy.
- ☐ **The company claims any ownership or long-term rights to your manuscript.**
If you are paying for assisted self-publishing services, make sure you understand exactly what rights, if any, you are granting. Your contract should clearly explain copyright, royalties, creative control, and termination terms.
- ☐ **Pricing changes dramatically once you show interest.**
Be cautious when a quote suddenly shifts because of a supposedly urgent or limited-time offer. Professional publishing decisions should not require artificial pressure.
- ☐ **No itemized breakdown of what you're paying for.**
You should be able to see exactly how much you are paying for each service: editing, design, formatting, distribution, marketing, or any add-ons. A single unexplained number makes comparison difficult.

COMMUNICATION & PROCESS

- ☐ **You can't get a straight answer to a direct question.**
Deflection, over-promising, or “let's discuss on a call” instead of a written answer is a stalling tactic.
- ☐ **No named, reachable point of contact once payment is made.**
If the friendly sales rep disappears the moment the contract is signed, that's the pattern authors report most before a project goes dark.
- ☐ **High-pressure, time-limited sales tactics.**
“This price is only good today” is a sales script. Real publishing decisions don't need to be made in the next hour.
- ☐ **Heavy upselling before the first deliverable is even finished.**
Being pitched five additional “premium” services before your edit is done suggests revenue—Your book is not the priority

PROMISES & CLAIMS

- ☐ **The company guarantees bestseller status, specific sales numbers, or a movie deal.**
No legitimate publishing service can guarantee how readers, retailers, or the market will respond to a book. Ask what actions the company will take, not what outcome they promise.

■ PART ONE, CONTINUED

Red Flags, Continued

- ☐ **Testimonials that can't be verified anywhere outside their own website.**
Check for independent reviews on Trustpilot, the BBB, or Reviews.io — not just quotes on the sales page.
- ☐ **"We'll get you into bookstores" with no explanation of how.**
Physical bookstore placement and wholesale distribution are not the same thing. Ask:
 - Which distributor will be used?
 - Will the book be available for wholesale ordering?
 - Is the book returnable?
 - Does "bookstore availability" mean ordering availability or guaranteed shelf placement ?
- ☐ **Marketing described only in vague terms like "we'll promote your book everywhere."**
Ask for specifics: which platforms, what budget, what reporting you'll receive, and how "success" is measured.
- ☐ **Reluctance to explain the difference between their packages in writing.**
You should be able to compare packages side by side and understand exactly what changes from one option to another.
- ☐ **No clear revision or return policy if you're unhappy with a deliverable.**
Ask what happens if you reject the first cover design or edit — the answer tells you everything about how they'll treat you after payment.

Scoring Yourself

0 boxes checked — proceed with normal diligence.

1–2 boxes — ask direct, written questions before paying anything.

3+ boxes — strongly reconsider, or ask a trusted, unaffiliated author or editor to review the contract with you before you sign.

A NOTE ON THIS LIST

None of these signs alone proves bad intent — small or new companies sometimes have imperfect processes for entirely innocent reasons. But when several of them stack together, they describe a consistent, well-documented pattern that authors have reported losing money to. Trust the pattern, not the pitch.

■ PART TWO

What Publishing Your Book Should Actually Cost

The following ranges are general industry benchmarks for a full-length manuscript of roughly 60,000 – 90,000 words. Actual pricing may vary based on:

- Manuscript length
 - Genre
 - Manuscript condition
 - Editor or designer experience
- Number of revision rounds
 - Complexity
 - Distribution requirements
 - Marketing scope

SERVICE	TYPICAL RANGE	WHAT AFFECTS THE PRICE
Editing	\$800–\$5,000+	Copy editing (lightest touch) through full developmental editing (structure, plot, pacing). Priced per word or per hour; genre and manuscript condition matter.
Cover Design	\$300–\$2,000	Template-based custom covers sit at the low end; fully original illustrated art or hand-lettered typography sits at the high end.
Interior Formatting	\$150–\$800	Ebook-only formatting is cheapest; print formatting (paperback plus hardcover, InDesign layout) costs more due to trim size and margin work.
ISBN & Registration	\$0 –\$125	Free if self-assigned through some regional agencies; ranges depend on country and whether you need separate ISBNs per format.
Global Distribution	\$0–\$500	Many retailers (Amazon KDP, IngramSpark) charge no setup fee; paid tiers add wider wholesale and library distribution.
Marketing & Launch	\$500–\$6,000+	Depends heavily on scope: organic social setup versus paid ad campaigns, review outreach, and press coverage.

IF A QUOTE IS FAR BELOW THIS RANGE

Ask what's being cut. Extremely low prices usually mean a single editing pass instead of multiple rounds, template covers with no customization, or AI-generated work with no human review.

IF A QUOTE IS FAR ABOVE THIS RANGE

Ask exactly what's included at each price point. High prices aren't automatically wrong, but they should map to a clearly itemized scope, not a vague “premium” label.

■ PUTTING IT TOGETHER

Are You Ready to Say Yes?

Before you sign with any publishing partner—Collingwood Press included—you should be able to answer these plainly.

You're Ready When...

- You have a written, itemized breakdown of every service and cost.
- You know exactly who your point of contact is after you pay.
- The contract explicitly confirms you retain full rights and royalties.
- You've checked at least one independent review source (BBB, Trustpilot, Reviews.io).
- You understand the realistic timeline, not just an optimistic one.

You Need More Information When...

- Any pricing feels rushed, bundled, or hard to break down.
- You've been shown testimonials but haven't verified them independently.
- You're not clear on what happens if you're unhappy with a deliverable.
- Marketing promises are described as outcomes ("bestseller") rather than actions (specific channels, specific spend).

0 FLAGS

Proceed with a normal, healthy level of due diligence. Ask your questions and move forward with confidence.

1-2 FLAGS

Get clear, written answers before paying anything. A trustworthy company will welcome the questions.

3+ FLAGS

Pause. Get a second opinion from an unaffiliated author, editor, or the resources above before signing.

Publishing your book is a big decision, but it doesn't have to be a scary one. The right partner will welcome every question on this page — not avoid them.

■ A NOTE FROM COLLINGWOOD PRESS

Why Authors Choose Collingwood Press

You don't have to take our word for any of this — every claim below is something you can independently verify before you ever pay us a dollar.

BBB Accredited Business

Collingwood Press holds active Better Business Bureau accreditation — a status that requires meeting the BBB's standards for truthful advertising, transparency, and responsiveness to customer complaints. You can look up our exact rating and complaint history directly on bbb.org before signing anything, which is more than most publishing companies will let you do.



Independent Book Publishers Association (IBPA) Member

Collingwood Press is a member of the Independent Book Publishers Association (IBPA), the largest publishing trade association in the United States. IBPA supports the independent publishing community through professional education, industry advocacy, networking, and resources designed to promote responsible publishing practices. This membership reflects our commitment to established publishing standards and best practices as we guide authors through the process.



Trustpilot

Verified client reviews

Reviews.io

Independent ratings

G2

Listed seller profile

1,500+ Authors Published

From debut writers to established authors across fiction, nonfiction, and memoir — a track record you can cross-check against real, verifiable titles.

Full Rights, Every Time

You retain 100% of your copyright, royalties, and creative control before, during, and after the project. It's written into every contract, not just promised on a call.

A Named Human, Not a Ticket Number

Every author is assigned a dedicated project manager who is reachable by phone throughout the entire process — not just during the sales conversation.

Global Distribution Network

Real distribution relationships across Amazon, Apple Books, Kobo, IngramSpark, Barnes & Noble, and more — the same names listed in this guide's cost benchmarks.

Transparent, Itemized Pricing

Every quote breaks down exactly what you're paying for — editing, design, formatting, and marketing priced separately, never bundled into one unexplained number.

End-to-End Capability

Ghostwriting, editing, cover design, formatting, ISBN and distribution, marketing, and audiobook production — one accountable team instead of a chain of freelancers.

The takeaway: everything on this page is something a predatory publisher, by definition, can't offer — verifiable accreditation, named accountability, and a paper trail you can check before you commit.

A WORD FROM COLLINGWOOD PRESS

You Don't Have to Navigate This Alone.

We built this checklist because we've spoken to too many authors who got burned before they ever found us. Whether or not you ever work with Collingwood Press, we'd rather you publish safely than not at all.

- 1** Transparent, itemized pricing.
Every quote we give breaks down exactly what you're paying for — no bundled mystery packages.
- 2** You keep every right to your work.
Full copyright, full royalties, full control — before, during, and after we work together. Not negotiable.
- 3** A named human, not a ticket number.
Your project manager is reachable by phone throughout your entire project, not just before you sign.

NEXT STEP

Get a Free, No-Obligation Manuscript Review

A real editor reads your work and gives direct feedback within 5–7 days — no automated reports, no pressure to buy anything.

WEBSITE

thecollingwoodpress.com

EMAIL

info@the-collingwoodpress.com

PHONE

+1 (936) 223-3644

COLLINGWOOD PRESS